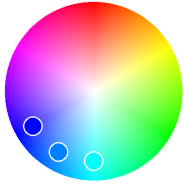


Color Harmonies for Websites

What each harmony looks like, and when to reach for it (or not)



Analogous

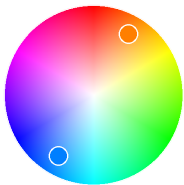
Three hues that sit next to each other on the color wheel, within about 60° of each other. Low contrast between the hues themselves, so the palette feels cohesive and calm.

USE FOR

- Backgrounds, layered surfaces, and content-heavy pages where hues need to blend, not compete
- Wellness, editorial, and reading-focused sites where a calm register matters
- Building a range of related UI surface colors (cards, panels, hover states) that still feel like one family

AVOID WHEN

- The site needs one element to visually shout above everything else — low contrast makes strong CTAs hard to achieve
- Users are color-blind to that hue range — analogous hues sitting close together are the hardest to distinguish for red-green or blue-yellow color blindness



Complementary

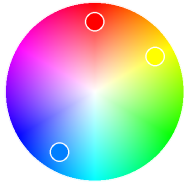
Two hues directly opposite each other on the wheel (180° apart). This is the highest-contrast pairing available, which makes each color visually pop against the other.

USE FOR

- A single accent color against a neutral or brand-dominant background — e.g. one orange CTA button on a blue-themed site
- Drawing the eye to exactly one interactive element per view
- Sports, retail, and energetic brands wanting bold visual impact

AVOID WHEN

- Using both hues in equal, large areas — opposite hues at full saturation next to each other cause visual vibration and eye strain
 - Body text and background pairs — stick to one hue for text and the other purely as an accent
 - More than one competing CTA is needed on the same screen — complementary contrast dilutes if repeated
-



Split-complementary

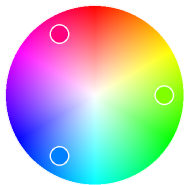
One base hue, plus the two hues adjacent to its complement (instead of the complement itself). Keeps strong contrast but is gentler and easier to balance than a straight complementary pair.

USE FOR

- Sites that want complementary-level visual interest without the harshness — **a good default for most marketing sites**
- A primary brand color plus two accent colors for secondary actions, badges, or categories
- Beginners to color theory — harder to get visually wrong than a straight complementary pair

AVOID WHEN

- A very minimal, single-accent brand identity is the goal — three hues is more than a strict one-accent system needs
- Strict brand guidelines already define a single fixed accent color — don't introduce a third hue without approval



Triad

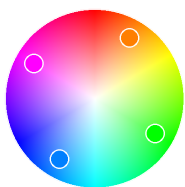
Three hues spaced evenly around the wheel, 120° apart. Vibrant and well-balanced since no hue dominates by proximity to another.

USE FOR

- **Gamified, playful, or youth-oriented products — XP, streak, and reward-state colors often map naturally onto a triad**
- Data visualization and category tagging where 3 distinct, equally-weighted colors are needed
- Illustration-heavy or brand-forward sites wanting personality over restraint

AVOID WHEN

- A restrained, professional, or enterprise tone is the goal — triads read as energetic and can feel unserious in that context
- All three hues are used at equal saturation and size — pick one dominant hue and use the other two as smaller accents



Square

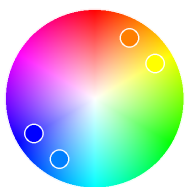
Four hues spaced evenly, 90° apart. Maximum hue variety of any harmony on this list — high energy, but the hardest to keep balanced.

USE FOR

- Rich dashboards or data-heavy interfaces needing four clearly distinct categorical colors
- Illustration and iconography systems where variety is the point

AVOID WHEN

- Almost any typical marketing or content site — four competing hues at similar weight usually reads as noisy rather than intentional
- There isn't a strong, clearly dominant hue to anchor the other three — without a lead color, a square palette has no visual hierarchy



Compound (tetradic)

Two complementary pairs positioned close together rather than evenly spaced — a rectangle on the wheel, not a square. Rich and flexible, but needs a clear dominant hue to stay readable.

USE FOR

- Brand systems that need a wide color vocabulary — e.g. a product with several sub-brands or content categories
- Editorial or magazine-style sites layering a few accent hues across different sections

AVOID WHEN

- Working solo or on a tight timeline — this harmony takes the most deliberate balancing of any on this list
- A clean, minimal aesthetic is the goal — compound naturally pulls toward visual richness, not restraint



Shades

A single hue varied only in lightness — adding black or white to the same base color. The simplest harmony to execute and guaranteed to feel cohesive.

USE FOR

- Building a full UI neutral/surface scale (backgrounds, borders, hover states) from one brand hue
- Minimalist or monochrome-branded products where restraint is the identity
- Data visualizations that need to show intensity or magnitude of a single variable

AVOID WHEN

- The interface needs to communicate different meanings (success vs. error vs. warning) — shades of one hue can't carry that distinction reliably, especially for color-blind users
- The brand wants to feel vibrant or energetic — single-hue systems tend to read as calm or serious



Monochromatic

Like shades, but saturation is varied along with lightness — giving both muted, desaturated tints and deep, saturated tones from the same base hue.

USE FOR

- Same use cases as shades, with more visual range — muted tints for backgrounds, saturated tones for emphasis, all from one hue
- Sites wanting a distinctive single-color identity without looking flat

AVOID WHEN

- Same limitation as shades — avoid relying on it for semantic meaning (status, correctness, alerts)
- Fast visual scanning is critical — similar-hue, similar-saturation elements take longer to visually differentiate than distinct hues

General rule: most real sites don't commit to one harmony type across the whole palette. A common pattern is analogous or monochromatic for the neutral/surface system, with one complementary or triadic accent layered on top for calls to action and semantic states.